TEAM STORYLINE REFERENCE

The Digital Circus: Cracks in the Act

Full level-by-level narrative outline · playable protagonist: Pomni

Pre-Level 1

ORIENTATION

Suggested name: *"Business as Usual"*

> **Purpose:** Introduce the world through Pomni's already-familiar POV, without her breaking character to explain things — the player learns by watching her react, not by being told.

- Player controls Pomni in the main tent going through an ordinary circus morning. Presented in 3D exploration; dialogue triggers drop into a Persona-style overlay (2D portraits in the corners, text box below).
- Casual banter with Ragatha establishes the cast (Caine, Kinger, Gangle, Zooble, Jax, Ribbit) and Pomni's dry, weary tone.
- Jax passes by, visibly on edge — a wordless tell that something is wrong before anyone says so directly.
- Ragatha's tone drops: something happened between Jax and Ribbit, and it's changed him.
- Pomni goes to find Caine, who confirms it: Jax and Ribbit had a serious fight, Jax has been harsher and more volatile since, and Ribbit has gone quiet — a warning sign for **abstraction**.
- Caine's tone breaks from showman-bit to genuine worry as he explains abstraction: the fail state where a character who spirals too far stops being themselves.
- Caine asks Pomni to check on Ribbit, then says **he'll go check on the rest of the circus himself**, to make sure everyone else is okay.

Design note: this scene plants the abstraction threat purely through dialogue, so it lands as lore before it ever becomes a UI mechanic.

Level 1

RIBBIT

Suggested name: *"Talk Her Down"*

> **Goal:** Help Ribbit calm down before the tension from her fight with Jax pushes her toward abstraction.

- Pomni finds Ribbit withdrawn and shaken. This is the game's first **dialogue-choice sequence** — the player picks responses that either ease or escalate Ribbit's distress.
- As Ribbit opens up, she reveals a second thread: Jax has also been lashing out at **Kaufmo**, mocking him as "crazy" for believing he can find a way out of the circus.
- Level ends with Ribbit stabilized, and the player's attention redirected toward Kaufmo for Level 2.

Scoring: every dialogue choice here is graded. Good choices add points to the **Escape Threshold**; every bad/wrong choice earns **zero** points.

Level 2

KAUFMO

Suggested name: *"Missing Pieces"*

> **Goal:** Find proof to reassure Kaufmo and pull him out of his spiral.

- Pomni finds Kaufmo pacing in circles in his room, spiralling as he tries to prove the circus has an exit.
- Exploration task: find **3 objects** scattered around the circus (framed as pictures of the real-world C&A office) that support his theory.
- Kaufmo takes the objects/pictures from Pomni, thanks her, and says these were the missing pieces he needed.
- He tells Pomni he'll come find her once he's worked out the answer — setting up his return in the finale.

Scoring: each item actually found and presented to Kaufmo = 1 point toward the **Escape Threshold** (out of 3 possible). Presenting only 1 of 3 items means only 1/3 points — a low score.

Level 3 — Final Level

JAX

Suggested name: *"Into the Maze"*

- Pomni, Ribbit, and Kaufmo try to approach Jax together. He bolts into a maze.
- Pomni chases him, calling out *"Jax, wait!"* — Kaufmo and Ribbit, who happen to be passing, witness this and follow her in.

3.1 — Echoes

- **Timed search 1:** find a bowling ball (tied to memories with Kaufmo). On success, Jax spawns nearby (still behind a few walls). Kaufmo runs to him with the ball, reminding him of good times and the exit evidence — and that he misses him. Jax takes the ball and flees again.
- **Timed search 2:** find a hot chocolate mug (tied to memories with Ribbit). On success, Jax spawns nearby again. Ribbit approaches, reminding him of their café wind-downs. Jax takes the mug and flees again.
- If a search timer runs out without the item found, Jax still spawns nearby regardless — the chase always continues, but without the emotional beat (and without the points below).

3.2 — Face to Face

- Kaufmo and Ribbit stay back; Pomni asks to approach Jax alone.
- She finds him glitching. Final **dialogue-choice sequence** begins — the emotional climax of the game.

Jax's Fate meter: a second hidden meter, separate from the Escape Threshold, built entirely within Level 3 — points from the 3.2 dialogue choices, plus bonus points for each item (bowling ball, mug) recovered in 3.1. Its final value determines whether Jax is saved or abstracts.

How the Two Meters Decide the Ending

Gate 1 — Escape Threshold

Built from **Level 1** (Ribbit dialogue) + **Level 2** (items presented to Kaufmo). Falls short → the party never finds a way out, no matter what happens with Jax.

Gate 2 — Jax's Fate

Built from **Level 3** (3.1 items + 3.2 dialogue). Only comes into play once the Escape Threshold is cleared — decides whether Jax is saved or abstracts.

True Happy Ending

Escape Threshold cleared, **and** Jax is saved in 3.2.
The group escapes the circus together, Jax included.

Bittersweet Ending

Escape Threshold cleared, but Jax abstracts in 3.2.
The group escapes — without him.

True Bad Ending

Escape Threshold **not** cleared (weak L1/L2 performance).
The party never finds the exit; if Jax also abstracts, this is the game's worst outcome.

Not yet pinned down: what happens if the Escape Threshold is missed *but* Jax is still saved in 3.2. Currently folded into the True Bad Ending (no escape = failure state regardless of Jax) — worth confirming with the team, or splitting into its own 4th ending if you want that nuance.

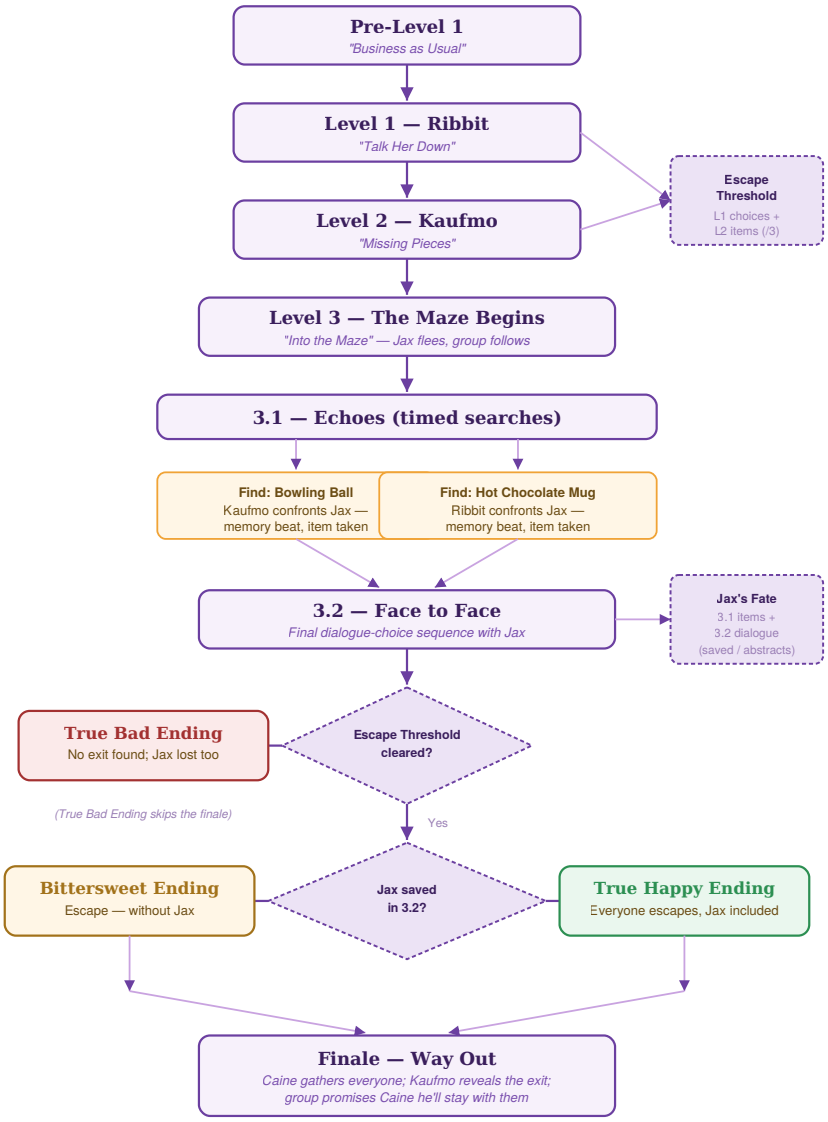
Ending

WAY OUT

(True Happy / Bittersweet variant — the party has cleared the Escape Threshold)

- Pomni returns from the maze. Caine approaches her.
- Pomni tells him there's an exit, and asks him to gather everyone else in the circus.
- Caine snaps the whole group together on the spot; Kaufmo explains how to reach the exit.
- Caine grows anxious — unsure whether he's even able to leave.
- The group reassures him: once they're out, they'll keep him with them by keeping him on their phones.
- If Jax is with them: he's part of this scene too. If he abstracted in 3.2, the group leaves without him — the bittersweet variant.

Sequence Diagram



Names marked with a pill are suggestions — swap freely before this goes in the pitch deck.